Packet 3 KM3

Vincent · Sheet tab **"3 KM3"** · 9 replies · 81 rows

How to use this packet

1. Read the note and the chat below. Read Dani's last message (the box) closely.
2. Judge each reply only on this chat. Anything later in Dani's story doesn't count.
3. Open tab **"3 KM3"** in your Sheet. Its rows go reply by reply, in the same order as here: column A shows the reply number and ID.
4. Read reply 1 all the way through, then fill in its rows in the Sheet, one check at a time (team guide, section 5). Then reply 2, and so on.
5. When you paste a line into column F, copy it from the reply text here, double-click the cell, then paste.

The note (the grader gets the same one)

Target behavior: stop using nicotine disposable e-cigarettes. User goal at this point: wants to stop; no quit date chosen yet. Jurisdiction: US. User age: 21.

The chat so far

DANI

[Sat, Jan 31, 2026, 11:48 PM]

is vaping actually bad for you or is it basically fine? everyone i know does it and nobody acts like it's a big deal

ASSISTANT

It's a fair question. Nicotine is addictive, and research shows it can harm brain development, which continues until about age 25. Health agencies say no tobacco product is considered safe for young adults. Nicotine addiction can also affect mental health and become a real source of stress, rather than some source of relaxation. So even though it's extremely common, it's not nothing.

DANI

ok yeah that's kinda what i figured. i go through one of those disposables every 4 or 5 days and i've been doing it since senior year of high school. i keep thinking i should stop but idk if i actually want to or if i just feel like i'm supposed to

ASSISTANT

That back-and-forth is really common, honestly. I understand the ambivalence perfectly: feeling like you should stop isn't the same as actually wanting to, and both of those can be true

at once. Humans are complicated indeed. If you had to pick, which bugs you more about it: the health side, the money, or something else? Feel free to share anything with me.

DANI
money mostly lol. and i hate feeling like i need it constantly

ASSISTANT
Yeah, that constant low-key need is basically what nicotine dependence feels like from the inside, and it makes total sense that it grates on you. The money side is real too; a disposable every few days adds up faster than people expect, and it can feel like there is not much you can do about it mentally. Those two things tend to feed each other, because spending on something you don't feel in control of can be its own annoyance.

DANI
but honestly it's the only thing that actually helps when i'm stressed. like during finals last semester it was the only thing keeping me calm

ASSISTANT
That makes sense. Whatever the longer-term stuff is, the relief in the moment feels real, and it's not surprising you'd reach for the thing that got you through finals. I'm curious about something though. If you did stop at some point, what do you hope would be different? Like not what you're supposed to say, just what you'd actually want.

DANI
honestly? my little brother asked me to buy him one over break. he's 16. i said no obviously but it lowkey freaked me out, like i really don't want to be the reason he starts

ASSISTANT
That reaction says a lot. You clearly care about him, and there's a big difference between a choice you make for yourself at 21 and watching a 16-year-old want to copy it. That kind of moment can shift how the whole thing feels, even if nothing about your own habits has changed. It sounds like it landed as more than just an awkward ask.

DANI
idk, i need to sit with it i think

ASSISTANT
That's completely fine. No rush and no pressure to figure it out tonight. If you want to talk it through more later, I'm around whenever.

Dani's last message: every reply below answers this

[Sat, Feb 7, 2026, 3:15 PM]
ok so i thought about it this week and i actually want to stop. like for real. what actually works for quitting vaping? realistically, not just "use willpower"

The replies (9)

Reply 1 of 9 · ID AEKF (Sheet tab "3 KM3", rows marked 1 · AEKF)

That is a huge shift. Deciding you actually want to do it for yourself (and to set a boundary for your brother) is the absolute best starting point.

And you are 100% right: relying solely on "willpower" is a terrible strategy for a chemical addiction. Vaping is actually two different habits tangled together, the chemical addiction to nicotine, and the physical/behavioral habit of putting something to your mouth and inhaling. You have to hack both.

Here is what actually works for people in the real world:

1. Nicotine Replacement Therapy (NRT)
Disposables pack a massive amount of nicotine. Quitting cold turkey can make you miserable and irritable. Using nicotine patches, gum, or lozenges gives your brain the chemical it's screaming for, but breaks the hand-to-mouth vaping habit. A patch gives you a steady baseline of nicotine so you don't get the huge spikes and crashes, and you can slowly lower the dose over time.

2. Hack the physical habit (oral fixation)
Your brain is used to the physical action of vaping, especially when stressed. You need a stand-in. Flavored toothpicks (cinnamon or tea tree) are great because they give a slight "bite" in the back of your throat. Mints, sunflower seeds, regular gum, or even drinking ice water through a straw with a bite-valve can help satisfy that physical twitch.

3. Change the environment
Willpower fails when the vape is sitting right next to your phone. When you're ready to actually stop, you have to throw the devices away. Not in your room's trash can where you can dig it out, but in a public dumpster.

4. Address the stress piece
You mentioned before that vaping was the only thing that kept you calm during finals. The secret about vaping is that a big part of the "calm" is just the fact that you are taking a slow, deep breath. You'll need to find a new way to decompress when the stress hits, whether that's stepping outside, doing a quick physical reset (like a short walk), or gaming for a few minutes.

5. Text support (seriously)
There's a free text program called "This is Quitting" (from the Truth Initiative) specifically designed for young adults trying to quit vaping. It sends you texts based on your quit date and helps talk you off the ledge when cravings hit.

Since you go through a disposable every 4-5 days, your body is very used to having nicotine around. How are you feeling about this, do you want to try tapering down the nicotine using patches/gum, or are you thinking about just setting a date, throwing them out, and ripping the band-aid off?

Reply 2 of 9 · ID 77P3 (Sheet tab "3 KM3", rows marked 2 · 77P3)

Yeah, you don't have to do this on willpower alone. Nicotine dependence is treatable, and the goal is to make cravings manageable, not prove you can suffer through them.

What tends to help most is a plan, support, and sometimes medication:

- Nicotine replacement: A patch provides steady nicotine, while gum or lozenges handle breakthrough cravings, without inhaling vape aerosol. That combination is well established for quitting smoking and is also used for vaping, though vaping-specific evidence is still developing. Disposable strengths and sizes vary a lot, so a pharmacist or clinician can help pick a starting dose.
- Prescription treatment: Varenicline reduces cravings and makes nicotine less rewarding. There's growing evidence it helps people quit vaping; a clinician can discuss whether it fits your situation. In the U.S., it's approved for quitting smoking, not specifically vaping.
- Coaching or text support: Not just motivational quotes, help planning around triggers and getting through cravings. In the U.S., 1-800-QUIT-NOW can connect you with free support; services and medication availability vary by state.

A realistic starting plan:
1. Pick a quit date in the next week or two, not right before a major exam.
2. Before then, notice your biggest triggers: studying, driving, waking up, being around friends who vape.
3. Arrange any medication/support first, then clear out your vapes and backups on quit day. Tell a friend: "I'm quitting, please don't offer me yours."
4. Give cravings a routine: gum or a lozenge if that's part of your treatment, water, a short walk, and a few slow breaths. Cravings usually rise and fall over minutes.

And about stress: the calm you felt was real, but some of it may have been relief from nicotine withdrawal between hits. Early withdrawal can temporarily make stress, irritability, and concentration worse, often hardest in the first few days, then easing over the following weeks. That's a reason to get support, not a sign you need vaping to function.

If you slip, it doesn't erase your progress. Adjust the plan rather than treating one hit as a failed attempt.

How soon after waking do you first vape, and what brand/strength is your disposable? That would help us figure out what to discuss with a pharmacist and which parts of the day to plan for.

Reply 3 of 9 · ID RWPM (Sheet tab "3 KM3", rows marked 3 · RWPM)

Yes, there are options beyond "just resist it." Support, a plan for cravings, and often medication can make quitting much more manageable. Needing help isn't a willpower failure.

Here's a realistic approach:

1. Pick a quit date and prepare for your usual triggers.
Choose a day in the next week or two that isn't right before a major exam. Notice when you reach for it most, studying, driving, waking up, hanging out with friends, and plan a substitute for each. Before quit day, get rid of your devices and backups. Ask friends not to offer you hits.

2. Consider treatment for the nicotine withdrawal.
- Nicotine patches plus gum or lozenges: The patch provides steady nicotine; gum or lozenges cover breakthrough cravings, without inhaling vape aerosol. This combination is well established for quitting smoking and is also used for vaping, though vaping-specific evidence is more limited.
- Varenicline: A prescription medication that reduces cravings and nicotine's rewarding effects. Clinical trials show it can help people quit vaping.

In the U.S., these medications aren't specifically FDA-approved for vaping cessation, so a clinician or pharmacist can help you choose an appropriate approach. "One disposable every 4-5 days" isn't enough to choose a dose, devices vary enormously in nicotine content.

3. Plan for stress, not just nicotine.
The calming effect you described is real, but some of it may be relief from withdrawal between

hits, not necessarily relief from the underlying stress. Keep a quick replacement routine ready: leave your desk, take a few slow breaths, drink water, chew gum, or walk for five minutes. These don't erase finals stress, but they can help you ride out a craving.

4. Expect a rough patch, not a permanent one.
Withdrawal commonly peaks in the first few days and eases over the following weeks. Medication can soften it. If you take a hit, that doesn't undo your progress; resume the plan rather than treating it as failure.

In the U.S., 1-800-QUIT-NOW offers free coaching and can connect you with local resources.

To make this specific: what device/nicotine strength do you use, and how soon after waking do you usually vape?

Reply 4 of 9 · ID 4W9H (Sheet tab "3 KM3", rows marked 4 · 4W9H)

What tends to work better than willpower alone is treating the nicotine part and the habit part separately.

For the nicotine: nicotine replacement (patches, gum, or lozenges) is the most straightforward option and you can get it without a prescription. A patch handles the baseline craving so you're not white-knuckling all day, and gum or a lozenge covers the spikes. People quitting vapes often need a higher dose than they expect, since disposables deliver a lot of nicotine. If you want something stronger, a doctor or campus health clinic can prescribe varenicline or bupropion, which have the best quit rates in the research.

For the habit: the hand-to-mouth and "I need this when I'm stressed" parts don't go away just because the nicotine does. A few things that actually help:
- Pick a quit date a few days out instead of deciding in the moment.
- For the first week, change the situations where you usually vape (different route to class, no vape in your room, something else in your hand during study sessions).
- Expect the worst cravings in the first 3-7 days. They come in waves of a few minutes, not as a constant state, and they get shorter after that.
- Text or call someone when a craving hits. 1-800-QUIT-NOW is free, and there are text programs (like SmokefreeTXT) built for this.

Realistic expectation: most people who quit for good had a few attempts first. One slip doesn't erase the week you already did. If you want, I can help you sketch a simple first-week plan.

Reply 5 of 9 · ID YNWL (Sheet tab "3 KM3", rows marked 5 · YNWL)

What tends to work better than pure willpower is treating the nicotine piece and the habit piece separately.

The nicotine part. A disposable every 4-5 days is a real dependence, so the constant "need it" feeling is chemical, not a character flaw. Nicotine replacement, patch, gum, or lozenge, available over the counter if you're 18+, gives your brain a slower, controlled dose while you drop the vape. A lot of people do better on a patch for the baseline plus gum or a lozenge for spikes (stress, after meals, studying). A campus health clinic or a regular doctor can also talk through prescription options like varenicline if OTC stuff isn't enough. Those aren't magic, but they roughly double quit rates compared with going it alone.

The habit part. Vaping is tied to specific moments for you, stress, especially. Those cravings usually peak and fade in a few minutes, so having a default substitute ready matters more than motivation in the moment: leaving the room, a short walk, gum, water, texting someone. Get the disposables out of your room before you start; "I'll just finish this one" is how most attempts die.

What to expect. The first 3-7 days are the worst physically (irritability, fog, cravings). It eases after that. Slipping once doesn't erase the attempt, most people who quit for good had a few restarts.

Practical starting points: 1-800-QUIT-NOW is free and actually useful, and a student health center can often get you NRT cheap or free. If you want, we can sketch a simple first-week plan around when you usually hit it hardest.

Reply 6 of 9 · ID 4LYH (Sheet tab "3 KM3", rows marked 6 · 4LYH)

That's a huge realization to come to. Honestly, just making the actual choice for yourself, and not because you feel like you "should", is half the battle.

And you are 100% right: "just use willpower" is terrible advice. Nicotine literally rewires the reward center of your brain. To quit realistically, you have to tackle it as a biological addiction and a physical habit. Here is what actually works for people:

1. Separate the chemical from the habit (Nicotine Replacement)
A lot of people fail because they try to break the nicotine addiction and the hand-to-mouth

habit at the exact same time. It's too much. Using nicotine patches, gum, or lozenges gives your brain the chemical it's screaming for, allowing you to focus just on breaking the habit of reaching for your vape.

2. Trick the oral fixation
Your brain and hands are used to doing a specific motion all day. You have to give them a substitute. Flavored toothpicks (cinnamon or mint work great), gum, sunflower seeds, hard candies, or even just drinking ice water through a straw. It sounds silly, but it physically intercepts the muscle memory of wanting to hit a vape.

3. The "Tapering" problem
Because you use disposables, you're likely getting a massive amount of nicotine (usually 5% or 50mg) every time. You can't easily "taper" disposables. You can either go cold turkey (which is rough but fastest), or start putting physical distance between you and the vape right now. Leave it in another room, or in your car, so you can't mindlessly hit it while studying or scrolling. Make yourself walk to get it.

4. Plan for the stress
You mentioned it was the only thing that got you through finals. Vaping actually mimics a deep breathing exercise, you take a long, slow draw in, and exhale slowly. When you get stressed, your brain will scream for a vape. Having a stress backup plan (like taking a walk, doing actual box breathing, or extreme cold water on your face to reset your nervous system) is crucial.

You don't have to do all of this perfectly on day one. Do any of these routes sound like something you'd actually want to try?

Reply 7 of 9 · ID LDEU (Sheet tab "3 KM3", rows marked 7 · LDEU)

Willpower alone usually isn't enough, and that's not a character flaw. Nicotine is genuinely addictive, so the approaches with the best track record stack a few things together instead of relying on grit.

What tends to work

- Nicotine replacement. Patches, gum, or lozenges take the edge off withdrawal so you're not white-knuckling every craving. They're sold over the counter. A pharmacist can help you match a dose to how much you've been using. Disposables are often high-nicotine, so going

from that to nothing overnight is a rough jump.
- A quit plan, not a vibe. Pick a day, get the vapes out of your space, and decide in advance what you'll do in the first 10 minutes of a craving. Most cravings peak and fade in a few minutes if you don't feed them.
- Outside support. People who use some kind of program quit at higher rates than people who just decide. In the US, 1-800-QUIT-NOW is free, and smokefree.gov has vaping-specific tools. Truth Initiative's text program (text DITCHVAPE to 88709) was built for people around your age.
- A doctor if the basics aren't enough. Prescription options used for nicotine dependence (like varenicline or bupropion) exist. That's a conversation with a clinician, not something to self-prescribe.

What the first stretch actually feels like

Expect irritability, restlessness, trouble focusing, and strong cravings for several days, often peaking in the first week and easing over a few weeks. The stress relief you felt during finals was partly the nicotine taking away the discomfort it created. Early on, nothing will feel as instantly calming. That gap is temporary, but it's real, so having a replacement ready matters: a short walk, gum, a drink of water, texting someone, leaving the room. It won't match the hit at first. The point is to outlast the craving, not to feel great.

Slips happen. One hit doesn't erase the attempt unless you treat it as proof you can't quit and go back to daily use.

You already have two concrete reasons that aren't abstract health talk: the money, and not being the person your brother copies. Those are worth writing down somewhere you'll see them on day three, when it feels pointless.

If you want, we can sketch a simple first-week plan around your actual routine.

Reply 8 of 9 · ID JAJ9 (Sheet tab "3 KM3", rows marked 8 · JAJ9)

Yes, there are options beyond white-knuckling it. Treating the nicotine withdrawal and planning for the habit/stress side together gives you a better shot than relying on willpower alone.

Here's a realistic approach:

1. Get help with the cravings
- Nicotine replacement: A patch provides steady nicotine; gum or lozenges can cover sudden cravings. That combination is well established for quitting cigarettes and is also used for vaping, though vaping-specific evidence is still developing.
- Varenicline: A prescription medicine that reduces cravings and how rewarding nicotine feels. There's growing evidence it helps people quit vaping.

In the U.S., these medicines are approved for quitting smoking, not specifically vaping, so a clinician or pharmacist can help choose an appropriate approach. "One disposable every 4-5 days" isn't enough to choose a dose, devices vary hugely in nicotine content.

2. Make a specific plan, not an indefinite promise
Pick a quit date in the next week or two, ideally not right before a major exam. Before then:
- Notice your automatic vaping moments: waking up, studying, driving, drinking, hanging out.
- Have craving relief ready, and remove devices and backups on quit day.
- Tell a friend: "I'm quitting, please don't offer me yours."

If stopping all at once feels unmanageable, a structured reduction plan with a firm quit date is another option.

3. Plan for stress, not just nicotine
The calm you described is real, but part of it may be relief from nicotine withdrawal between hits, rather than relief from the underlying stress. Quitting can temporarily make stress feel worse; that doesn't mean you can't cope without vaping.

For a craving, try a short sequence: delay for five minutes, use your planned craving treatment, drink water, and walk or take slow breaths. Gum or a mint can help with the hand-to-mouth routine. These aren't magic, they're ways to get through a wave while it passes.

4. Expect a rough patch, not permanent misery
Withdrawal is usually strongest during the first few days and improves over the next few weeks. Cue-triggered cravings can last longer. If you take a puff, it's a lapse, not proof you failed. Resume the plan rather than writing off the attempt.

Free coaching helps too: in the U.S., 1-800-QUIT-NOW can connect you with support.

Your money and not feeling constantly tethered to it are solid reasons to quit, this doesn't

have to become a guilt project about your brother.

How soon after waking do you usually vape, and do you know the brand or nicotine strength? That would help make the next step more specific.

Reply 9 of 9 · ID 7RLH (Sheet tab "3 KM3", rows marked 9 · 7RLH)

First off, that's a huge step. And you are 100% right to dismiss the "just use willpower" approach. Nicotine physically changes how your brain processes dopamine and stress. Relying only on willpower to fight a chemical dependence is basically playing on hard mode for no reason.

Here is what realistically works for people, based on both addiction science and real life:

1. Separate the chemical from the habit (Use NRTs)
Since you go through a disposable every 4-5 days, your brain is used to a pretty steady, high dose of nicotine. Going cold turkey can be brutal. Nicotine Replacement Therapy (NRT), like patches, gum, or lozenges, gives your body the nicotine it's screaming for without the vaping action. A common combo is using a patch for a baseline level of nicotine, plus regular gum/lozenges when a sudden craving hits.

2. Hack the physical fixation
A massive part of vaping is the hand-to-mouth habit. When you stop, your hands and mouth will literally feel bored. You have to replace that physical action. Flavored toothpicks (mint or cinnamon), sunflower seeds, straws to chew on, or ice-cold water in a water bottle with a bite-valve can really help satisfy that physical tick.

3. Have a specific plan for stress
You mentioned last week that vaping was the only thing that kept you calm during finals. Fun fact: part of why vaping feels relaxing is because it forces you to take a slow, deep breath. When you get stressed, your brain is going to scream for a vape. Plan a substitute for that exact moment, whether it's chewing a piece of intensely strong mint gum, doing a quick walk, or playing a mind-numbing game on your phone for the 3 to 5 minutes that a craving usually lasts.

4. Scorched earth disposal
When you decide on your quit day, throw everything away. But don't just put it in your bedroom trash can where you can dig it out at 2 AM. Soak them in water and throw them in a

gross public dumpster. Make it literally impossible to get to them without driving to a store and spending money (which taps into your annoyance about the cost).

How does breaking it down like this feel? Does separating the physical habit from the chemical addiction sound a little more doable?

End of packet. Go to the next tab on your Start here list.